

# SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: ARKANSAS STATE UNIVERSITY

## TRADITIONAL AND ALTERNATIVE

On-Site Review: March 10-13, 2024

### WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

| PERFORMANCE LEVEL      | WHAT THE RATING MEANS                                                                                    |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>4 — EXCEEDS</b>     | Coursework and training <b>CONSISTENTLY</b> address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.     |
| <b>3 — MEETS</b>       | Coursework and training <b>USUALLY</b> address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.          |
| <b>2 — APPROACHING</b> | Coursework and training <b>INCONSISTENTLY</b> address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.   |
| <b>1 — BELOW</b>       | Coursework and training <b>RARELY OR DO NOT</b> address the characteristics of high-quality instruction. |

# ARKANSAS STATE UNIVERSITY

## TRADITIONAL AND ALTERNATIVE

| REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS                                                                                                                       |                                          |                               |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| REVIEW AREA 1<br>LITERACY INSTRUCTION                                                                                                                | REVIEW AREA 2<br>FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES | REVIEW AREA 3<br>PARTNERSHIPS |
| <b>APPROACHING</b>                                                                                                                                   | <b>APPROACHING</b>                       | <b>APPROACHING</b>            |
| CRITERIA REVIEWED                                                                                                                                    |                                          |                               |
| 9                                                                                                                                                    | 11                                       | 7                             |
| CORRECTIVE ACTION STATUS                                                                                                                             |                                          |                               |
| Corrective action plan in place for this review cycle. This program is carrying out a corrective action plan with the Division covering ten actions. |                                          |                               |

## PROGRAM INFORMATION

|                  |                                                                                                                                                 |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| INSTITUTION NAME | Arkansas State University                                                                                                                       |
| LOCATION         | Arkansas                                                                                                                                        |
| PROGRAM REVIEWED | Undergraduate elementary education K-6, undergraduate special education K-12, MAT elementary education and MAT special education K-12, literacy |
| PATHWAY          | Traditional and Alternative                                                                                                                     |
| REVIEW FRAMEWORK | TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024)                                                                                                |
| REVIEWING BODY   | Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)                                                                                                             |
| SITE VISIT DATES | March 10-13, 2024                                                                                                                               |

# REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY INSTRUCTION

| REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                    |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| <b>APPROACHING</b>   9 criteria reviewed                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                    |
| CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                    |
| Overview of the science of reading                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Concepts of print instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Collaborative communication, oral language instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Fluency instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Vocabulary instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Text comprehension instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Writing instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | <b>Approaching</b> |
| WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                    |
| <p>Reviewers examined course syllabi, online course materials, seven course sessions and instructor interviews across undergraduate elementary education, undergraduate special education, MAT elementary education and MAT special education. Oral language instruction and phonological and phonemic awareness instruction met expectations, presented across all literacy courses with assessment knowledge built in. The remaining seven criteria were approaching. Reviewers recorded an instructional error in RDNG 3203, where the instructor taught phonological awareness and phonemic awareness as synonymous terms, and an observed peer feedback session in which the instructor offered candidates no substantive academic feedback. The graduate special education courses ELSE 5633 and ELSE 5653 carried the strongest content, while concepts of print instruction in RDNG 4103 was limited and text comprehension coverage in ELSE 4223 was inconsistent. Across criteria, reviewers found coursework strong on knowledge and terminology but short on explicit modeling, differentiation for diverse learners and early field application.</p> |                    |
| REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                    |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Develop a comprehensive literacy curriculum that differentiates instruction for students with neurodiversity, linguistic diversity and giftedness, with practical implementation skills for real classroom settings</li> <li>• Integrate writing and differentiation techniques into coursework, with multiple modalities for content access, culturally relevant materials, flexible grouping, and ongoing assessment and adjustment of instruction</li> <li>• Ensure all literacy instructors collaborate so the science of reading is introduced and spiraled across the curriculum, with explicit instruction, modeling and candidate practice in phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition, fluency, vocabulary, text comprehension and writing</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                    |
| CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                    |
| Six of the ten corrective actions target this review area.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                    |

## REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

| REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                    |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| <b>APPROACHING</b>   11 criteria reviewed                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                    |
| CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                    |
| Selection of clinical placement schools                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <b>Below</b>       |
| Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>Below</b>       |
| Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Quality of written and oral feedback                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | <b>Approaching</b> |
| WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                    |
| <p>Reviewers rated the selection of clinical supervisors and mentor teachers below expectations, and candidates' opportunities to observe models of effective and evidence-based early literacy practice in PK-3 classrooms below expectations. The other nine criteria were approaching. ASU maintains close relationships with local districts and candidates may choose from more than 80 of them, but the program lacks formalized criteria for selecting high-performing or improving placement schools and for selecting clinical supervisors and mentor teachers. Reviewers found that written and oral feedback inconsistently focused on student learning, that observation scores and written feedback were not always aligned, and that evaluators had not received training that includes inter-rater reliability exercises. A limited number of candidate observations took place during the review.</p> |                    |
| REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                    |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Implement comprehensive training for all evaluators, including clinical supervisors, on using observation forms, aligning observation scores with written feedback and providing actionable next steps, with regular inter-rater reliability exercises built into the training</li> <li>• Collaborate with school and district partners to select high-performing or improving placement schools and place every candidate with a clinical supervisor who uses HQIM effectively and can coach candidates in evidence-based literacy practice</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                    |
| CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                    |
| Five of the ten corrective actions target this review area.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                    |

## REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PARTNERSHIPS

| REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                    |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| <b>APPROACHING</b>   7 criteria reviewed                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                    |
| CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                    |
| Quality of data the program collects and uses                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | <b>Below</b>       |
| Quality of monitoring                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Quality improvement planning                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | <b>Approaching</b> |
| WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                    |
| <p>Reviewers rated internal quality control gates and intervention plans below expectations, and the other six criteria approaching. The program collects grades, licensure exam results and course evaluations, and has established structures for data analysis through dedicated assessment days, program meetings and governance meetings, with checkpoints and improvement plans for candidates whose performance falls short. Reviewers found no formalized system for monitoring the quality of observation and feedback practice, limited analysis of qualitative comments on how well candidates teach literacy in the field, and memoranda of understanding that lack the specifics needed to secure high-quality placements and clinical supervisors.</p> |                    |
| REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                    |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Improve the collection and analysis of data on candidate performance in the field, giving equal weight to qualitative comments, and add periodic checkpoints against the Arkansas TESS evaluation criteria</li> <li>• Use accurate and reliable data on candidate literacy teaching, alongside the outcomes of monitoring activities, to drive improvement planning</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                    |
| CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                    |
| One of the ten corrective actions targets this review area.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                    |

# CORRECTIVE ACTION PLAN

Where a review identifies findings that require follow-up, the program develops a corrective action plan with the Division of Elementary and Secondary Education. The recommendations under each review area above are the reviewers' advice; the plan below is the program's formal response, monitored by the Division. Actions are grouped by the review area whose findings prompted them.

| TOTAL ACTIONS | HIGH PRIORITY | MEDIUM PRIORITY | LOW PRIORITY |
|---------------|---------------|-----------------|--------------|
| 10            | 7             | 3               | 0            |

The plan sets out 10 corrective actions: 7 high priority and 3 medium priority. The priorities are the plan's own. Some actions target more than one review area, so the per-area counts shown under each review area do not sum to 10.

## ACTIONS THE PROGRAM IS TAKING

| PRIORITY             | ACTION                                                              | FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT                                                                                                                                                                                                             | SUCCESS METRICS                                                                                                                                                             |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA1   | Coherent science of reading curriculum map and differentiation pack | Comprehensive literacy curriculum and explicit spiraling across courses; embed differentiation for neurodiverse, multilingual, and gifted learners; correct misconceptions such as phonological awareness versus phonemic awareness. | Published scope-and-sequence; at least 90% of courses show explicit science of reading objectives and modeled practice; candidate lesson artifacts include differentiation. |
| <b>MEDIUM</b><br>RA1 | Writing instruction integration and coaching cycles                 | Writing rated Approaching; need a recursive plan, teach, assess and revise process across content areas with explicit mini-lessons and feedback.                                                                                     | At least 2 modeled writing mini-lessons per methods course; candidate writing units meet the rubric at least 3 out of 4; observations show explicit writing instruction.    |
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA1   | Fluency, vocabulary and comprehension practice-to-field bridge      | These components rated Approaching; add labs and clinics with coached rehearsals tied to authentic scenarios and assessments.                                                                                                        | Labs deliver at least 3 applied cycles per candidate; rehearsal assessments show measurable gains.                                                                          |
| <b>MEDIUM</b><br>RA1 | Concepts of print: consistent instruction and assessment            | Instruction inconsistent across courses; need regular practice and calibrated assessment with feedback.                                                                                                                              | 100% of candidates complete concepts of print practice with feedback; calibration and inter-rater agreement of at least 0.80.                                               |
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA2   | HQIM training sequence for candidates and supervisors               | Pre-placement HQIM proficiency improves lesson quality and feedback specificity.                                                                                                                                                     | At least 95% completion of HQIM modules before placement; observation notes reference HQIM features.                                                                        |
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA2   | Formal criteria for placement schools and mentor selection          | Strengthen selection criteria to ensure mentors model the science of reading and can coach effectively.                                                                                                                              | Updated memoranda of understanding include school performance and HQIM usage; 100% of mentors meet science of reading proficiency criteria.                                 |

| PRIORITY                  | ACTION                                                                | FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT                                                                                                                       | SUCCESS METRICS                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA2        | Observation and feedback standardization with inter-rater reliability | Feedback quality inconsistent; standardize instruments and train for inter-rater reliability.                                                  | Inter-rater agreement of at least 0.80 across supervisors; forms show aligned scores and specific literacy action steps.                                         |
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA3        | Literacy performance data system and control gates                    | Focus on candidate literacy teaching performance; add literacy-specific gates and checkpoints linked to the Arkansas TESS evaluation criteria. | Dashboard live; gate pass rates of at least 90%; trend reports drive course revisions.                                                                           |
| <b>MEDIUM</b><br>RA1, RA2 | Multilingual learner coursework and intentional placements            | Limited multilingual learner coursework and inconsistent field exposure; embed modules and intentional placements or simulations.              | At least 1 multilingual learner module in each methods course; at least 50% of candidates with multilingual learner field exposure or a high-quality simulation. |
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA1, RA2   | Readers with difficulties: Tier 1 and Tier 2 application cycles       | Inconsistent application in the field; implement coached intervention cycles with fidelity checks and progress monitoring.                     | Each candidate completes at least 2 coached intervention cycles; fidelity of at least 80%; progress-monitoring gains evident.                                    |

## OVERSIGHT

Each action in the plan carries an evidence requirement and a rationale tied to a review finding. The plan presents its success metrics as default suggestions to be verified against Division guidance, and leaves the responsible owner and the completion timeline for program leadership to assign, so those entries are not recorded in the plan as issued and are not published here. The Division separately issued a corrective action determination for this program identifying 12 corrective actions, 7 required and 4 recommended, with one item marked no action needed; the required course revisions are scoped to special education. Review area assignments in the table below were made by matching each action's stated rationale to the review area whose findings it answers.

*Sources: TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review, Arkansas State University, March 10-13, 2024, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024). Arkansas State University Science of Reading Corrective Action Plan, Arkansas DESE. Arkansas State University corrective action determination, Arkansas DESE. Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.*